

WW2: AUSTRALIA ON THE HOMEFRONT

MENZIES LOSS OF LEADERSHIP

On the outbreak of war, September 1939, Menzies headed a minority UAP Government. During August 1940, Menzies lost 3 trusted ministers in air crash; their positions were filled by 3 Country Party members. Conflicts with Page led to a collapse of the coalition. The Menzies government was re-elected in September 1940, with the support of only two independent politicians. Menzies sought a national coalition like the UK. The Labor party proposed an all-party advisory council. The Labor party then used its influence in council to gain wider social welfare.

Menzies travelled to Britain in early 1941 to urge the strengthening of Britain and on his return several members of his party were critical of his leadership. With little support from his party Menzies was forced to resign and Arthur Fadden of the country party took over losing the support of the 2 independents. Labor became the new government, with John Curtin becoming Prime Minister on the 7th of October 1941.

Apply your knowledge:

Using page 132 of Australia 1918-1950's textbook list three reasons as to why Menzies leadership weakened from June-August 1941

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

WAR CONTROLS

The first two years of the war had seen an unprecedented growth in Commonwealth powers, above what was once State control. These powers were intended to be temporary, yet they increased the prestige of the Federal government. The National Security Act of 1939 gave the government special powers to make new laws. It was argued that special powers could be needed urgently to deal with problems as they arose and before parliament could be assembled.

During the entire war 400 acts or amendments were made by Parliament but about 2000 regulations were made by the council. Thus, most new laws and changes to laws during the war were not made through parliamentary debate. The public was assured that they would only be used in the interests of national security.

Old acts were revived allowing the internment of 'aliens', making foreigners the first to lose their liberties. Most were allowed to travel freely on the condition they reported their movements and restricted their travel. Foreigners were restricted from certain occupations & the right to buy land, they were barred from owning motor vehicles, boats, radios, cameras, telephones and guns. New Acts declared that

goods essential for the war effort could be demanded from any factory. Those who seen as endangering public security were interned. The amendment to the National Security Act forced people to place themselves, their services & property at government's disposal.

There was government control over censorship. Keith Murdoch was appointed the Director-General of Information and he held wide powers to compel the media to print what they were informed by the government. Censorship was seen to be in the interests of morale. The powers were criticised by the press, resented by the public who at times were distrustful of the government, but the general consensus was that the war controls were a necessity.

Controls were placed on the economy with wheat being acquisitioned and wool and barley marketing being controlled. Rent levels were stabilized which was a positive however, rations were placed on clothing, meat, butter and sugar. There were quota's placed on beer, spirits and tobacco. It became illegal to produce civilian hat's cosmetics, jewelry or children's party frocks. As the war became more critical, more regulations were introduced. Taxes increased and the government took complete control of all shipping.

Any opposition to the war effort not was not tolerated. The Jehovah's Witnesses was declared illegal due to their anti-war views. Outspoken communists had denounced the war as capitalistic. The Communist Party was banned early in the war, but by 1942 it had been made legal again, due to their sudden and intense support for the war following Germany's invasion of the Soviet Union.

Under Curtin's Labor Government the powers of the government increased again with Curtin advocating rationing, which was the only way low income earners could have an equal chance to purchase things that were in short supply. Curtin's plan was to increase revenue by taxing high income earners and increasing excise on company tax. Wartime banking control regulations were introduced, requiring private banks to be licensed and accept government control of their lending policies and interest rates, allowing Commonwealth control over the amount of currency in circulation. An Austerity campaign began to encourage less spending to make money more available for the war effort.

In 1942 Curtin introduced ID cards as a method of monitoring Australia's population and identifying war threats. In the same year there was a reduction of holiday periods, daylight saving was introduced and restrictions were placed on sporting events, restraint opening times and drinking hours. These controls increased government spending and hundreds of boards were set up

Apply your knowledge:

1. Explain the purpose of Source 1.



Source 1: The front page of Australian newspaper "The Herald" on the 28th of December 1942.

2. Provide a brief assessment of the War controls of WW2 and whether they were necessary during WW2.

HOME DEFENCE

With the threat of invasion came blackouts, evacuation plans and barbed wire beaches. The Volunteer Defence Corps was formed holding 95,000 members by 1942. There were drills, sirens, shelters being dug, camouflaged public transport and reinforcing of buildings. Home defence enthusiasm waned as the risk of attack seemed to pass, but anti-Japanese propaganda was rife (and racist) cultivating a hatred of the Japanese, more so than Fascism.

Almost 250,000 American troops were stationed in Australia to a warm reception. They were welcomed as a safeguard, but their presence caused considerable resentment. The average US soldier earned 17 pounds a month, double of that of the Aussie troops: their spending power pushed up local prices, encouraging a black market. US troops were seen to get the best service from shopkeepers and taxi drivers. American men attracted the women too - 10,000 Australian women left to live in the US by the end of the war.

There were riots in Brisbane between US & Australian troops during 1943: two nights of rampage with bottles, bricks, guns and fists. The press was suppressed from making any reports. African-American troops were highly segregated; often clubs & hotels refused their service. Australia was still largely a racist society. Many 'black' US soldiers were sent to outback locations, building airfields and roads.

Fertiliser use in agriculture, and to a certain degree production, declined during the war due to a scarcity of superphosphate as Nauru had become occupied by the Japanese. A serious drought during 1944 reduced production further. Rubber tyres too were almost unobtainable due to the source of supply lost to Japanese expansion. Many skilled farmhands had left the land during the Depression; they enlisted during the war or took jobs in the expanding manufacturing industries. The war led to growth & diversification of Australia's industries as there was a need to manufacture home grown war materials. The lack of transportation led to problems with distribution. The growth of basic industries during the inter war years had allowed an effective industrial expansion during the war. The war brought employment back for many after a decade of unemployment. War did not eliminate industrial dispute; there were



Source 2: A propaganda poster produced in Australia in 1942.



Source 3: An Australian propaganda poster produced in 1942. Author unknown.

continued stoppages on some NSW Coalfields. By March 1942 government regulations meant that those who went on strike could be called up to go to war.

By 1943 it became increasingly clear that the war would be won. There became a gradual reduction in the numbers needed in the armed forces. Late in that year blackouts became no longer compulsory. People became less willing to accept the government controls. In 1944 Curtin wanted extended powers to last another five years to oversee a reconstruction period to create more equality after a period of sacrifice. His aim was to achieve higher employment and better living standards. The non-Labor State government did not grant Curtin's change to the constitution, which was lost in a referendum during 1944. Most Australians had come to resent the hundreds of wartime controls that had affected almost every aspect of their day to day lives. A political legacy of the war was that people began to accept Commonwealth power and control over the State governments. There had also been a decreased interstate rivalry which had contributed to sense of nationalism.

Apply your knowledge:

1. Explain the historical context of source 2.

2. Compare and contrast the messages of Sources 2 and 3.

WOMAN DURING THE WAR

During the 1940s women were initially offered skills to promote their uses in voluntary work, knitting, entertainment, and canteen work. But new organisations emerged: The Women's Emergency Signal Corps saw 300 Australian women trained to take over in Post Offices to release male employees for more war related tasks. Women joined the Australian Comforts Fund where they made over million balaclavas, hundreds of sets of gloves, pullovers, socks and prepared first aid kits. The National Defence League of Australia made 17,000 camouflage nets for the defence forces.

The Red Cross raised and spent 2 million pounds a year by 1943 for the war effort. Most of their funds were raised door to door. The Red Cross even offered a free nationwide transfusion service. The Women's Australian National Service (WANS) was formed in NSW to coordinate organisations to support state governments. During the war, 78,000 women enlisted in voluntary organisations.

The Women's Army Corps was soon formed and gained enormous support, even though many ridiculed their efforts. Membership increased however when Japan entered the war in December 1941. Another 45,000 joined the three major women's forces established during World War II - the Women's Auxiliary Australia Air Force (WAAAF), the Australian Women's Army Service (AWAS) and the Women's Royal Australian Naval Service (WRANS).

Women were taught how to drive and operate ambulances, trucks and to service aircraft. Women were taught to run exercises and promote air raid precautions, first aid clinics, military drill, shooting, mechanics, signalling and cooking.

After Singapore fell 15 Feb, 1942, the government began an intensive campaign to encourage women to join the workforce as it was seen as a huge, largely untapped, labour source. As more men enlisted, this required a greater contribution from women for the economy. The number of women employed in munitions factories rose from 1000 to 145,000 during the war. There was an element of resentment & opposition by some, the Catholic Church criticised using married women in the workforce, warning of the consequences of dramatic social change. Employers soon realised that women could fill many jobs at half the normal rate of pay to men, sometimes women were merely rewarded at only 2 thirds pay - the only exception being medical officers, where the Union insisted on equal pay. Trade Unions felt that general working conditions were under threat, as this could lead to a reduction in Men's wages.

There were no government plans to maintain women in work after the war. The Women's Employment Board was tasked to replace women with men as the men



Source 4: A poster produced by the Australian Department of National Service in 1943.

became available. There was a clear expectation that the war had and would not change the accepted idea of what women's primary roles were in society.

Increased wartime pressures were placed on women who were often expected to continue to fulfil all of those traditional duties at home too – often without the support of their male partners due to absences because of wartime commitments. No allowances were given by employers for mothers needing to be at home at certain times. There were often cases of an increasing rate of women absenteeism due to child care. Many children were simply left unsupervised and neglected. Juvenile delinquency was seen to increase; divorce rates heightened; some noticed a change in sexual morality. Public opinion was quick to blame women for society's increasing social problems.

By 1942, The Women's Land Army became a national organisation. By mid-1943 there were 2000 members. They received 4 weeks initial training. Accommodation was difficult to find and these women often travelled and frequently used bush camps covering vast distances. Farmers developed a strong respect for these women land workers. As the war drew to a close, they became the 'Forgotten Service', receiving no ex-service benefits.

Apply your knowledge:

1. To what extent did WW2 see a change in women's rights in Australia?

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are approximately 20 lines visible. On the right side, there is a small portion of a vertical margin line, creating a narrow right margin. The paper appears to be from a notebook or a standard ruled sheet.

INDIGENOUS AUSTRALIANS DURING WW2

The war interrupted the Aborigines Progressive Association that had demanded citizen rights & the abolition of the Protection Board. This was a period when the public were increasingly suspicious of dissident groups. Many Aborigines joined the armed forces: over 1000 joined 2AIF; more would have enlisted but the government stipulated only those with European descent were allowed. Most Aborigines experienced equality within the forces, although some received less money than their white comrades. Many Aborigines attained work in Australia because of the effects of the war. It was not until 1992 that they were finally awarded medals and remuneration.



Source 5: An special platoon made up of Indigenous soldiers in WW2.

During 1941 the Protection Board was abolished in NSW, a Welfare Board was set up with Aboriginal representatives. Child endowment payments became available to Aboriginal families provided they were not nomadic. This was extended to missions by 1942. Old age pensions later became available, but not to those on reserves.

At the end of war, citizens' rights were given to Aborigines but only if they applied for a certificate. If this certificate was lost, or if the holder was found drunken, had certain diseases; or did not adopt appropriate civilised habits, they lost those rights. Many Aboriginal people viewed the process as an insult to have to apply to be a citizen of one's own land.

Throughout this era, Aboriginal people continued to be the most socially and economically disadvantaged group.

Apply your knowledge:

1. List an example of where indigenous rights improved in the 1940's.
 - _____
2. List two examples where indigenous rights did not improve or worsened in the 1940's.
 - _____
 - _____

Extension task:

***On a piece of file paper use the 5 sources to answer the following;
"Using your knowledge of the period of study, evaluate the importance of the themes, ideas and or/events represented in the five sources"***